Mahayana, which injected a whole new layer of philosophical abstraction into Buddhism, according to some scholars, arose far from the mainstream monasteries of the Indo-Gangetic plain and was the work of fringe monastics like Nagarjuna.[29] Often called ‘the second Buddha’, his work is indispensable to several Buddhist schools. ‘Nagarjuna’s philosophy represents something of a watershed not only in the history of Indian philosophy but in the history of philosophy as a whole,’ writes Douglas Berger, a scholar of Indian thought, ‘as it calls into question certain philosophical assumptions so easily resorted to in our attempt to understand the world.’[30]

Not much is conclusively known about Nagarjuna’s life. Born into a Brahmin family, he became a Buddhist. Legend has it that he spent many years at a centre of learning that later evolved into the famous Nalanda University in modern-day Bihar, but there is no evidence for this at all. Many scholars consider his exposition of the concept of shunyata (‘emptiness’ or ‘voidness’) to be a critical achievement, central to a remarkable understanding of how we make sense of the world. He is best known for two surviving Sanskrit works: *Madhyamika Karika* (‘Fundamental Verses on the Middle Way’) and *Vigrahavyavartani* (‘The End of Disputes’), which analyse the nature of reality, how we perceive it and the basis of knowledge. His works should be thought of not only as a revival of the Buddha’s views on such topics—which, at the time, were losing ground to rival views within both Buddhism and Brahminism—but also as their further development. In the rest of this section, I’ll delve a bit deeper into Nagarjuna’s philosophy.

The Middle Way that Nagarjuna spoke of refers to the concept of dependent origination, i.e., the idea that there is no objective, mind-independent reality that’s accessible to us. This contrasts with the essentialist Brahminical view of the self (atman) and reality (Brahman), which posits that there is a true and universal reality that the human mind, with effort, can know.

Nagarjuna argued instead that what we make of reality inevitably depends on the cognitive structure of our mind, rather than on anything we can identify as an innate attribute of reality itself (*svabhava*). We understand the world through concepts, and there is no escape from our